story. No ‘hot line’ to Moscow existed in 1962 and McNamara was intensely unpopular with many senior officers, so accounts of his actions from military sources were often derogatory.

The following day, Sunday, 28 October, Khrushchev assembled the Presidium to agree on their retreat. In his letter to Kennedy that morning, he announced the dismantling and withdrawal of the missiles from Cuba. He also expressed his anxieties about the U-2 incident:

> One asks, Mr. President, how should we regard this? What is it? A provocation? Your aircraft violates our frontier and at times as anxious as those which we are now experiencing when everything has been placed in a state of combat readiness. For an intruding American aircraft can easily be taken for a bomber with nuclear weapons. This could push us toward a fatal step – all the more so because the United States government and Pentagon have long been saying that bombers with atomic bombs are constantly on duty in your country.[63]

There is no indication that the Presidium gave serious thought to using nuclear weapons. Yet is it possible that Moscow might have decided to ‘launch on warning’ and use rather than lose its missiles and bombers? This question is explored in chapter seven.

The once and future threat

In December 2018 the world-renowned naturalist and broadcaster Sir David Attenborough told the UN-sponsored COP24 conference on the climate crisis that humanity is ‘facing a man-made disaster of global scale’. [64] It was, he warned, ‘Our greatest threat in thousands of years … If we don’t take action, the collapse of our civilisations and the extinction of much of the natural world is on the horizon.’[65] At the COP26 conference in November 2022, Sir David asked: ‘Can we fix the climate problem in one generation?’ and gave the slightly more positive answer: ‘yes, we have to.’[66] Yet, the global temperature continues to rise, bringing increasingly